The 9th Degree – Elu of the Nine & 10th Degree –Elu of the Fifteen



The apron of the 9th Degree, an emblem of Masonry and Truth, is of white lambskin, lined and bordered with black. The candle, surrounded by darkness, represents the feeble light of ignorance, error and intolerance, with which the world is shrouded, and through which Masonry moves like a star, dispensing light and knowledge and toleration, symbolized by the star on the flap.

The jewel is a dagger, its hilt of gold and its blade of silver. These two metals in combination symbolize the brilliance of the combined light of the sun and the moon. We also see this meaning in the ancient Han characters of China where the character for “sun” is merged with the character for “moon” to form the character for “brilliant.” This dagger is not an emblem of false bravery but of the weapons of legitimate warfare, which an Elu of the Nine may lawfully use, and

especially of the two–edged sword of truth with which every Mason should be armed. A reference to this dagger is also found in the lecture for the Knight of the Brazen Serpent Degree, “Even the dagger of the Elu of the Nine is that used in the Mysteries of Mithras [a Persian deity]; which, with its blade black and hilt white, was an emblem of the two principles of Light and Darkness” (p. 506). We shall see this symbol repeated in the poniard of the 30th Degree.

The cordon is a broad, black watered ribbon, worn from the right shoulder to the left hip; from the end of the cordon hangs the jewel. At the lower end of this are nine red rosettes, four on each side and one at the bottom. The rosettes symbolize the original nine Elus or “Elected” who were chosen by King Solomon to seek out the assassins of Hiram. They also represent the nine virtues taught in this degree: disinterestedness, courtesy, devotion, firmness, frankness, generosity, self–denial, heroism and patriotism. The color of the cordon reminds us ever to lament the prevalence of ignorance, oppression and error. We should strive to overcome them by means of–the above excellent qualities of an Elu of the Nine.